“Take a very good look at it. You will never see it again,” Einstein had told Elsa as they left. Once the Nazis took over, Einstein, the most famous Jew in the world, was a marked man. Einstein’s stepdaughter managed to smuggle his papers safely out of his Berlin apartment before the Nazis could destroy them; Hitler’s goons ransacked the apartment four times in three days, but Einstein’s family and papers all made it out of the country. Einstein met his family and collected his belongings in Belgium, renounced his German citizenship, then returned to the United States, where he took up a post at the newly minted Institute for Advanced Study in Princeton. He remained in America for the rest of his life.

Physicists who lacked Einstein’s foresight but shared his Jewish heritage fled Nazi Germany after the Civil Service Act. They mostly landed in the United States and the UK, drastically shifting the center of the physics world (and changing the international language of physics from German to English). Max Born was unceremoniously suspended from his post at Göttingen. “All I had built up in Göttingen, during twelve years’ hard work, was shattered,” he wrote. “It seemed to me like the end of the world.” He and his family went to Cambridge for a time, then India, and ultimately resettled in Scotland for the duration of the war.

As Hitler expanded his control beyond Germany’s borders during the 1930s, more Jews who had the means to escape fled. By the Anschluss of March 1938, which united Germany with Hitler’s native Austria, many of the great Jewish intellectuals of Viennese culture had already left: Ludwig Wittgenstein was teaching in Cambridge, Karl Popper was a lecturer at the University of New Zealand, and Billy Wilder was writing lines for Greta Garbo in Hollywood. The best-known physicist in Austria, Erwin Schrödinger, wasn’t Jewish, but his wife was. Schrödinger had been at the University of Berlin in 1933 but had quit in protest when Hitler came to power. After Hitler invaded Austria, Schrödinger publicly recanted his anti-Nazi views, but this wasn’t enough for the new regime. Dismissed from his university post for “political unreliability,” Schrödinger fled to Ireland with his wife. Once there, he wrote a letter to Einstein, apologizing profusely for his “great duplicity.”

Italy’s Jews started to feel the pressure of the Nazi anti-Semitic policies after Hitler’s visit to Mussolini’s Fascist Italy in the summer of 1938. “The racial campaign… acquired momentum at an amazingly fast pace,” wrote